THE NEW GEOGRAPHY *of* LUXURY TRAVEL

With a changing paradigm that values immersion over opulence, affluent Indians are redefining luxury through experiential journeys, propelling spiritual pilgrimages, wellness retreats, wildlife safaris, and the pristine Northeast to the forefront of high-end travel.

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At the Ganga Aarti in Rishikesh, the air thickens with incense and anticipation. Temple bells echo across the valley. Priests lift towering brass lamps into the dusk, sending arcs of flame dancing against the darkening sky. Chants rise and fall with the river's current. Hundreds gather at the ghats, yet the experience feels curiously intimate, as though the spectacle is unfolding for each visitor alone. And then, just as easily, one can leave it behind.

A winding drive into the Himalayan foothills delivers a different kind of sanctuary. At The Westin Resort & Spa, Himalayas, the evening's devotional chants are replaced by the gentle fizz of a Jacuzzi, a well-chosen wine and a meticulously assembled cheeseboard. The appeal lies in moving effortlessly between worlds. The trend reflects a broader shift in how luxury is being defined now, as upscale travellers focus increasingly on experiences, not destinations, whether in spiritual towns, wildlife sanctuaries and wellness retreats, or in remote, unexplored parts of the country's Northeast.